that no infiltration was taking place. The results produced by us definitely surprised him the most.

We intercepted and neutralized a number of infiltrating groups within a period of about eight months in 1991. Terrorist organizations like the Hizbul Mujahideen, Lashkar-e-Toiba and Jaish-e-Mohammad, and their mentors across the LoC found the new counter-infiltration set-up in the Baramulla sector fairly difficult to penetrate. They identified me as the thorn in their flesh, as other than a change of command of the sector, nothing much had changed in the force level or deployments. Therefore, they decided to do away with me, and began making plans to achieve this mission. My formation was referred to as the 'Shaitan' (Devil) Brigade, and I was nicknamed as 'Shaitan' Singh. I was happy with both these appellations. It signified that we had been able to put the fear of God in the 'tanzeems'.

We launched a number of seek-and-destroy missions. The majority of the population acted as fence-sitters during such operations, keenly watching the contest between the jehadis and the army. As was expected, they usually gravitated to the winning side, and we appeared to them as clear winners due to our professional approach and the results of engagements. The terrorists were no match for us and the outcome showed it. We hardly lost any of our men, whereas we killed or apprehended many terrorists. Gradually, we won the people over to our side, specially in the rural 'kandi' (foothills) belt.

We always kept our principle 'iron-fist-and-velvet-glove' uppermost in our minds. This phrase was used by me during this tenure as a brigade commander. The iron fist was for the terrorist while the velvet glove was for the people, a vast majority of whom were innocent. We ensured that collateral damage was confined to the barest minimum. I had zero tolerance for any human rights violations, and made my views clear to all of my subordinates. The projection of the humane face of the army has always been my aim. By killing a terrorist or two the insurgency won't come to an end, but by killing or maiming innocents we were going to create many more terrorists. Very often I used to advise my COs to let go of an